2025

Submission to the Federal Inquiry into the 2025 federal election

[redacted] – BRADDON ELECTORATE

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[redacted]

Submission to Federal Parliament Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters 2025 election

My name is [redacted]. My address is [redacted], [redacted]. I live in the Braddon Electorate. I worked as a volunteer for the [redacted] Partly in the 2025 Federal Election. I completed following shifts on booths in Northwest Tasmania:

Shift Ref #	Date	Time	Booth	Other comments/details
1	28/04/2025	08:30 - 12:30	Pre-poll - East Devonport Recreation & Function Centre	2 x [redacted] volunteers on roster
2	29/04/25	12:30 – 17:30	Pre-poll - East Devonport Recreation & Function Centre	As above
3	02/05/25	13:00 – 18:00	Pre-poll – Ulverstone Civic Centre	As above with 1 additional volunteer in attendance
4	03/05/25	08:00 – 14:00	Polling booth – Penguin District School	3 volunteers in attendance on rotation in the time frame.

Details below refer to these shifts by the reference number on the table and each refers to one or more aspects of the inquiry. Maps have been provided to help show some details about the points in the submission.

Shift Reference # 1 East Devonport
The site has long entry driveway fenced off from the traffic going to the booth carpark and entry.

- *Subtle intimidation of others on the site*

Arrived at 07:30 to assist in putting up candidate corflutes. The [redacted] Party team had already taken up much of the space on the wire fencing on the driveway leaving limited room for other candidates to use (see Map 1 shown on page 5).

The [redacted] Party team was set up at the entry way with up to 5 people (see Map 2 on page 5). They had A Frames on the walkway parallel to the building and on the walkway to the booth entry. Their signs encroached on the boundary set by AEC for signage and were twice asked to move back and take down a sign.

The [redacted] Party team cars were parked directly in front of the booth walkway requiring voters to walk past them to enter the booth. Those who approached from the other direction walked past the small spaces where the teams of other candidates could set up. Each team had two volunteers.

- *More direct intimidation of voters and other candidates' teams*

Some of the corflutes of all the parties targeted the leadership of other parties rather than outline policy positions.

Three members of the [redacted] Party team consistently crossed in front of voters trying to queue or walk along the pathways to the booth entry presenting them with printed and verbal information, despite many stating they had decided how to vote and did not wish any materials. Having good parking and level walkways allowed voters with walking frames, walking sticks or aids and/or those who were accompanied by supporters/carers ready access. Having the [redacted] Party volunteers crossing in front of them obstructed their access.

At one stage one of the younger members of the [redacted] Party team commenced an argument with the [redacted] Party volunteer about a policy issue. Their language was loud, dismissive and argumentative talking over the [redacted] volunteer and consistently interrupting them. The [redacted] volunteer tried to refuse to engage and ended up taking a break.

The pattern of cutting across voter entry, at times telling voters not to take printed materials from other candidates was thinly disguised as "joking", ignoring the volunteers of other parties and being verbally critical of the other parties' candidates while voters were present continued throughout the shift.

- *Management of security on the site*

The AEC staff seemed able to manage aspects of safety for themselves and voters and provided opportunities for some voters with mobility and/or other conditions of vulnerability to be escorted into the booth especially when the queues became long and it was very cold on site.

Shift Reference # 2 East Devonport

- *Subtle intimidation of others on the site*

Similar pattern of behaviour of the [redacted] Party volunteers (many of whom were the same people as previous day) was in evidence on this day with the volume of corflutes and positioning at the booth entry. AEC officers asked them to take down signage within the boundary, to set back their A Frames and stand back to allow better voter access.

We were asked during a visit by the [redacted] candidate to report if any voters had mentioned being offered free coffee vouchers by the [redacted] Party volunteers as this had been identified at another booth. I heard no reports.

- *More direct intimidation of voters and other candidates' teams*

The younger volunteer from the [redacted] Party who was on site the previous day tried to loudly engage the [redacted] team in argument about a policy position, and we did not respond. The same volunteer also tried to separately engage two voters in arguments about why they did not wish to take the printed materials for the [redacted] Party candidate. The talked over the voters and shook their heads at them.

During the shift we heard reports that the members of the Northwest Tasmania section/community of the Plymouth Brethren Christian Church had come to the Devonport booth in the city and some voters, candidates and others reporting confronting behaviours. I did not identify any members at the East Devonport site (in previous roles I had encountered some so knew their faces).

Shift Reference # 3 Ulverstone Civic Centre

Ulverstone Civic Centre booth had two entries - one with stairs (See Map 3 on page 6) which faces divided traffic ways to the carpark. The other entry is around the back of the booth for those with mobility issues.

- *Subtle intimidation of others on the site*

The [redacted] Party team set up on the right-hand side of the stairs (as you look at the map) and obscured signage of the [redacted] candidate. [redacted] set up on the left-hand side of the stairs (as you look at the map) and obscured signage of the [redacted] and [redacted] candidates.

The volunteers were generally not friendly toward other parties' volunteers despite [redacted] and [redacted]s introducing themselves. When [redacted] Party volunteers had a shift change, the new team were friendly and offered a range of snacks and drinks to all volunteers. I did not observe them offering any to voters.

- *More direct intimidation of voters and other candidates' teams*

The team members of [redacted] and [redacted] Party consistently moved up and across the stairway in front of voters including those who needed to use handrails for support. They also set up on the entry walkways from both carpark and those on foot meaning voters were confronted twice by their volunteers as they navigated their way to the booth entry.

The [redacted] volunteers tried on two occasions to engage [redacted] and [redacted] teams in arguments and in one instance a volunteer from [redacted] engaged. The argument was conducted across the walkway where voters could easily hear, and the language was derisive by both sides. I noted this with the candidate who visited that day and agreed to address this with the volunteer.

- *Management of security on the site*

There was little evidence of security issues other than some voters strongly expressing their views about taking materials and having to vote so often given State elections. This did not target volunteers specifically – it was mostly directed to the site. The AEC staff did not address the proximity of the [redacted] and [redacted] Party teams standing on the stairs leading to the booth despite the AEC boundaries.

- *Voter access*

The walkway at the back of the booth for voters with mobility issues was not clearly marked so some voters were anxious about their ability to access the booth (See Map 4 page 6). As a local person, I was able to show all the voters who spoke to me and the volunteers where the mobility entry was so they could direct voters. Providing clear signage would have helped the voters as this location has a high number of elderly people and it was very cold.

Shift Reference # 4 Penguin District High School

- *Subtle intimidation of others on the site*

Penguin booth had an entry and exit for voters. [redacted] set up their area directly in front of the entrance to the booth thus obscuring capacity for other volunteer teams to approach voters and for voters to avoid making contact if they wished. The [redacted] party team was on average 6 members with most other teams having two or three.

The [redacted] candidate came to the booth and clearly identified to all on the site that a member of his family and their partner were volunteers for another party, approached them and engaged in family hugs etc and made jokes about what this meant for his campaign.

- *More direct intimidation of voters and other candidates' teams*

[redacted] was assertive in approaching voters and on several occasions did not accept that voters could refuse their materials. They tried to engage them by asking their reasons for not accepting their materials and telling them how [redacted] was the best leader for the country. Some voters got annoyed and asked them to stop so they could enter to vote. They also tried to engage other parties' volunteers in argument. Two such arguments occurred between a [redacted] Party team volunteer and [redacted] volunteer.

Both [redacted] and [redacted] volunteers "jokingly" told voters they needed to see all the coloured materials or that they did not need materials from the [redacted] or [redacted] volunteers as they were the wrong colours. I wondered about the terminology of "colour" especially after The Voice referendum.

One voter aggressively demanded of a [redacted] volunteer if the plastic banners used by [redacted] were environmentally friendly and began to deride the party and the candidate. The volunteer did not engage although I noted they began to respond but decided not to pursue this.

- *Management of security on the site*

[redacted] set up an A Frame on a sidewalk way and large signs on skip bin close to the booth entry. An AEC member asked for this to be taken down. Initially, the volunteer team questioned the AEC Officer who reiterated that this should be moved back. When the [redacted] volunteer team changed shift, one AEC officer spent over an hour talking in a very friendly manner with their volunteer at the entry to the booth. They did not ask for the replaced [redacted] A Frame to be removed.

- *Voter access*

The entry and exit to the booth were not clearly marked for voters or volunteers. Some voters waited at the exit until someone inside the booth told them where to gain entry. After seeing direction, candidates' volunteers were able to tell voters where to enter. It would be beneficial to have AEC clearly indicate entry and exits for voters.

Other aspects of the inquiry

Voter access had some limitations in some of the sites I attended. Tasmania reportedly has the highest proportion of ageing population in Australia and a high level of disability (including non-physical disability). As I have worked in many community roles, I was able to recognise some voters who struggled with too much stimulus, or having too many people approaching them, and those who subtly indicated they could not understand the printed materials especially the options of how to vote either above or below the line. It would be helpful in election campaigns if there were more resources in languages other than English and plain language as well as additional options for "quiet" voting with information about site locations provided to community support services as well as voters. I believe having early voting supported voters with vulnerabilities and gave them opportunities to avoid voting day queues and the general atmosphere of the day (especially sites with democracy sausages).

In the lead up to the election, I did letter box dropping and door knocking and while only verbally abused once, I did identify two persons who did not really understand how to see, read and lodge their postal vote. I also encountered two young people who asked why they needed to vote in this election as Tasmania was its own country and just had its election.

As Tasmanians had a recent State election and, in some seats, was scheduled for a Legislative Council election within short time frames, it was confusing to the voters. At least ten at each site I attended stated they had voting/election campaign fatigue. In my experience, Tasmanians have a lower level of governance understanding than I have experienced living in three other states and one territory. As a state which has a population of 557,571 at last census (see: https://www.abs.gov.au/census/find-census-data/quickstats/2021/6) with 29 municipalities (see: https://www.lgat.tas.gov.au/tasmanian-councils) it may contribute to why the population is not be clear on what might be a reasonable number of elected representatives for them in the national government. It may be helpful to have information for Tasmanians that explains levels of governance and outlines comparisons of the state with other jurisdictions to highlight the differences and outline why they may not have the level of representation they feel they deserve.

I also see the value of national government having longer than three-year terms so that policies they present to build national strengths can be better achieved. Governing at a national level under our constitution supports capacity for building future, rather than having short term initiatives tried, tested and then running out of time to learn from what they achieved.

I think that the number of signs each party can have during an election and at voting sites would be better to be clearly identified to both reduce costs and to lessen "election campaign fatigue". It would be interesting to see what evidence supports the efficacy of signage for determining voting decisions to assist in identifying a suitable number of signs allowed especially in the current environment of mis-information, creator and influencer messaging and inability to identify the truthfulness of information provided (see: https://www.aec.gov.au/faqs/electoral-communication.htm).

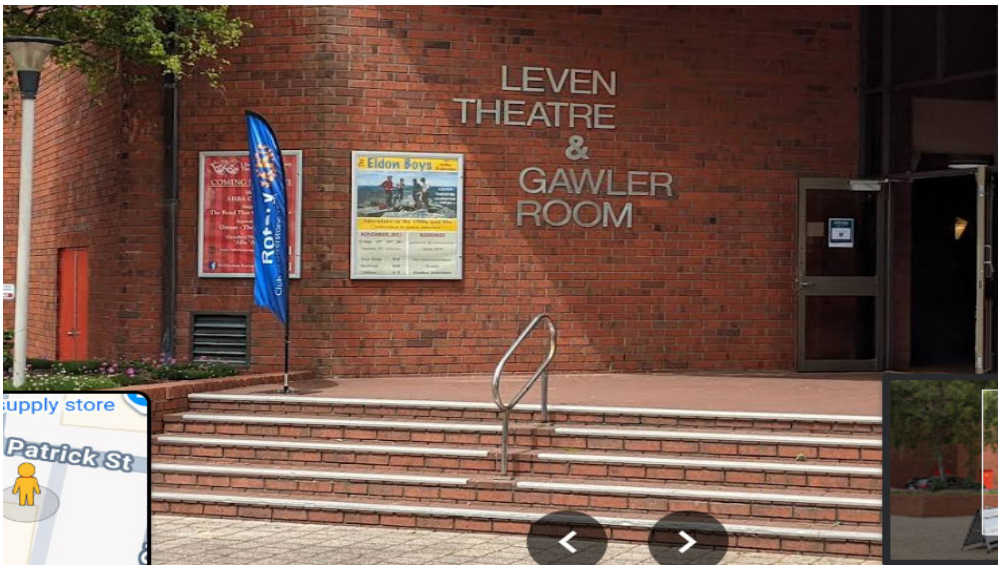
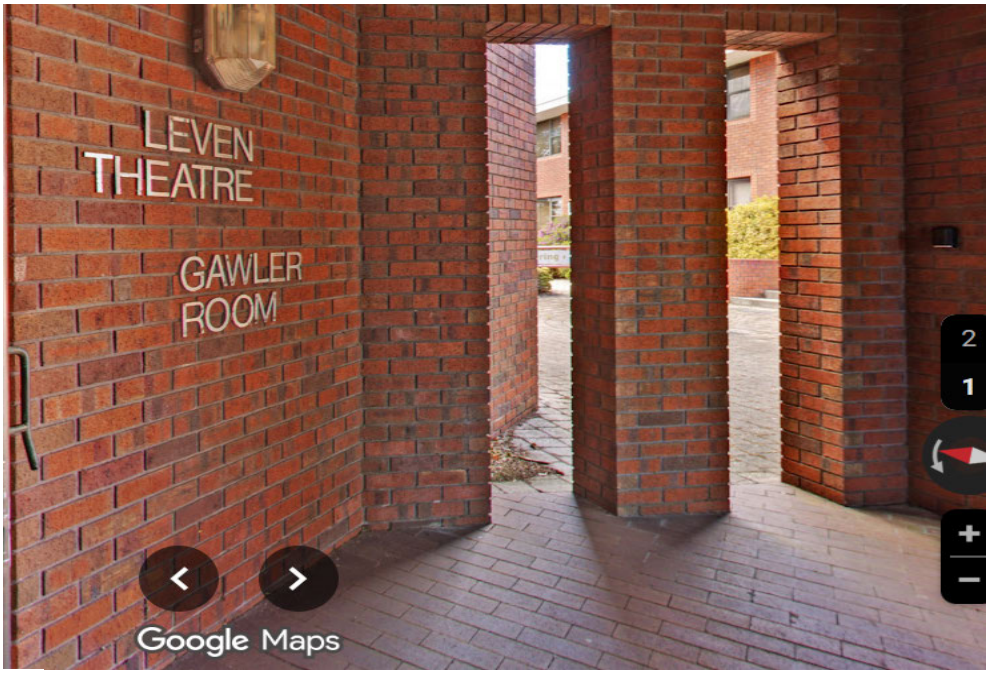
From my experiences during the 2025 election campaign, it was clear that the [redacted] candidate in my electorate had a greater volume of resources than other parties – more volunteers, volunteers equipped with branded T-shirts, jackets (it was cold!), caps and who received quite a variety and quantity of refreshments. They had a larger number of corflutes and A Frames. The candidate was new to the electorate, so it did not initially occur to me there was anything unusual about the level of resourcing. However, recent questions about the level of support provided to each party for this election and what the implications the types of support may have on the quality and transparency of our election processes in the longer term have been raised. It is not easy to address this, but we may need to open discussion in the population about what could be the implications on democracy of unfettered, biased influences and "funding for causes or returns" that can be used in election campaigns, especially when one considers the governance understandings/literacy of the population.

Maps of sites

Map 1 – East Devonport Recreation & Function Centre driveway from Caroline Street to the booth and carpark.

Map 2 - East Devonport Recreation and Function Centre showing the car park and short walkway from carpark to the entry of the booth

Map 3 – Ulverstone Civic Centre main entrance to the pre-poll booth



Map 4 – Ulverstone Civic Centre mobility entrance behind the booth